

"Is This Your True Intention to Participate?" — Simulated Interrogation and Hidden Control in an Agent-Driven Installation

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Figure 1: Exhibition installation from the *Interrogator* series, designed as an immersive environment that combines interactive activities. This figure shows the setup on site and details in phase 2. © Yuyang Jiang

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Abstract

As crime becomes increasingly technology-driven and complex, questions of agency and moral responsibility demand renewed scrutiny. Drawing on cultural criminology and art psychology, this

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project examines how AI-driven systems can operate simultaneously as tools of introspection and mechanisms of control. Informed by case studies and professional interviews, we created the *Interrogator* — a series of interactive artworks employing affective computing methods such as facial expression recognition and conversational analysis. Across two exhibitions, the artworks immersed visitors in interactive, technology-driven encounters that encouraged self-awareness and reflection on their own actions and agency. This project underscores the potential of interactive art to transform emerging technologies into sites of critical thinking on agency and responsibility.

CCS Concepts

• **Applied computing** → **Media arts**; • **Social and professional topics** → Technology and censorship.

Keywords

Interactive Art, Cultural Criminology, Agency, Participation, Affective Computing

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1 INTRODUCTION

In recent years, the global landscape of crime has undergone a significant transformation. Although traditional offenses remain persistent, the rise of technologically mediated infractions has introduced new challenges to ethical, legal, and institutional frameworks [Abbott and Sarch 2019; Qin et al. 2022]. Cybercrime alone is projected to generate losses annually [Chapman et al. 2022; Pulimood et al. 2022], with identity theft, phishing, ransomware, and artificial intelligence(AI)-driven fraud becoming increasingly sophisticated [Cybersecurity Ventures 2025]. In parallel, studies reveal a rapid increase in AI-facilitated academic misconduct, raising alarms about honesty and self-reflection [Spyropoulos 2024].

As the boundaries between legitimate, illicit, and ambiguous behaviors become increasingly opaque, efforts to algorithmically detect crime face new epistemological limitations. Criminality is no longer easily defined by technical criteria alone, but is embedded in dynamic systems of intention, performance, and sociocultural context. In response, scholars have emphasized the importance of intrinsic motivation, moral agency, and self-regulation as preventive frameworks [Gottfredson and Hirschi 1990; Rest et al. 2000]. Rather than relying solely on external enforcement or predictive surveillance, these approaches emphasize reflection, responsibility, and individual conscience as critical dimensions of criminological thinking [Sarmiento et al. 2024]. Cultural criminology extends this focus by conceptualizing crime as a cultural act, stylized, expressive, and symbolically mediated. Deviant behaviors are not only enacted, but also narrated and circulated through visual, auditory, and spatial systems that shape how transgression is perceived. Based on the analysis of monitoring, discipline, and performance theories, it criticizes the phenomenon that these institutions not

only impose punishments but also construct reflective subjectivity and reconstruct cognitive patterns [Migurski and Carden 2009; Xu and Zhai 2009]. Among the practices that most clearly materialize this logic, interrogation stands out as a paradigmatic form [Li et al. 2024]. It functions not merely as an information extraction method, but as a psychological performance structured by asymmetries of knowledge, authority, and vulnerability.

Agency — the capacity of individuals to act independently and to make their own free choices. As Anthony Giddens reminds us [Giddens 1984], “*to be a human being is to be a purposive agent, who both reproduces and transforms the social world through action.*” Similarly, Michel Foucault situates agency within regimes of power [Bandura 1997], where freedom is always negotiated against structures of surveillance and control. Building upon these thoughts, we raised the question: In the era of AI, what forms of interrogation could catalyze self-reflection rather than coercion? To explore these questions, we performed a fieldwork, including interviews with professionals in institutional settings. These conversations revealed how questioning, monitoring, and behavioral regulation practices are enacted in real-world contexts, and how institutional roles shape the perceived legitimacy and affective impact of interrogation — insights that directly guided our artistic practice.

We developed an agent-driven installation that stages interrogation as both a spatial choreography and an affective interface in the artworks (see Figure 1). Centered on a virtual agent, the system simulates an institutional encounter in which participants are subjected to emotional monitoring, adaptive questioning, and behavioral feedback. Technologically, it integrates affect recognition, large language model dialogue, and real-time agent animation [Ibrahim and Chen 2023]. Designed as a single-viewpoint environment, the installation emphasizes control, ambiguity, and embodied tension. The project was carried out through two successive exhibition stages, which allowed us to examine how visitors interacted, communicated, and reflected under the supervision of the interrogation agent over time. In summary, this art practice and study draw on interdisciplinary perspectives from cultural criminology, institutional aesthetics, and AI ethics to frame a conceptual understanding of interrogation, agency, and emotional computation.

2 BACKGROUND AND RELATED WORK

2.1 Expansion of Surveillance

The rise of predictive police technologies employs modeling to predict where, when, and by whom crimes are likely to occur [Dodd et al. 2021; Pulimood et al. 2022]. These technologies detect deception, aggression, or risk through facial micro-expressions or vocal stress responses, contributing to a growing field of algorithmic judgment [Rayhan and Hashem 2023]. Within this expanded surveillance apparatus, AI systems increasingly function not as neutral tools, but as agents of norm enforcement, embedded with institutional priorities — articulate how algorithmic vision not only classifies but also constructs identities through computational hierarchies of legibility and trust. Agency, in this context, is not merely a human attribute delegated to machines, but an operational mode of AI systems embedded in real-world governance structures [Schreiber 2024; Sundar 2020]. However, AI emerges as

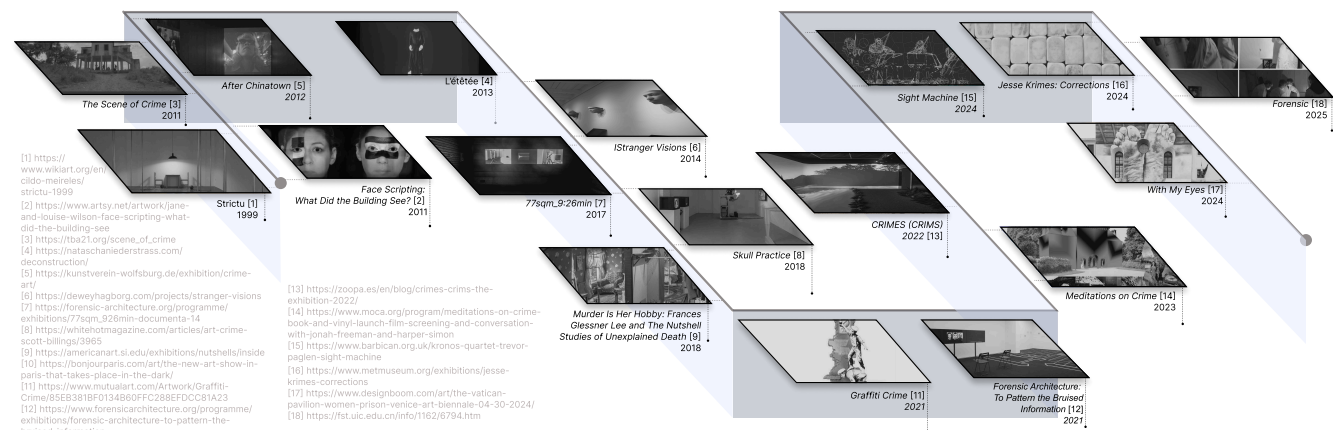


Figure 2: Outline the Sequence: Case studies from the artist’s works informed by the topic of society and crime, designed to evoke emotional resonance as a mode of commemoration in static arts [Banksy 2021; Dewey-Hagborg 2014; Krimes 2024; Lee 2017], videos [Architecture 2017, 2020; Kanwar 2011] and interaction [Ebosogo 2022; Quartet and Paglen 2019].

a conceptual medium through which questions of power, identity, and subjectivity can be reimagined [Devedzic 2022].

2.2 "Seductions" of Crime

Cultural criminology attempts to understand crime by considering the context of culture and cultural processes, as articulated in theories of disciplinary power, forcing individuals to regulate themselves [Hayward et al. 2008; Presdee 2004]. Such logics have been critically reinterpreted by artists who address state violence and psychological trauma through representational strategies within the field of visual art, often foregrounding the symbolic expression of incarceration [Jain et al. 2021]. Meanwhile, practices from art therapy and criminal psychology indicate that expressive processes can cultivate empathy and a sense of identification [Isern et al. 2024], with projective methods framing this as the indirect articulation of internal states through externalized forms [Ilan 2019]. In this view, art becomes both a mirror of the self and a means of critically engaging with broader social issues [Hoffmann 2020].

2.3 Participating as a Mode of Perception

Participatory art, by its very spatial and temporal configuration, allows simulated ways of thinking, not as passive displays, but as activated environments that invite participants into roles of complicity, resistance, or reflexivity [Ferrell et al. 2015]. In simulating scenes, empathy, and even the study of confined spaces [Obirst et al. 2017], the audience becomes part of a situated encounter, subject to the spatial logics and emotional cues of the scenario [Amrute 2019]. Rather than merely observing, visitors perform within the frame [Mellor 2014] – Many interactive experiences have sought to activate participant reflection through affective or dialogical techniques, such as the emotional mirroring of *Mirror Ritual* [Rajcic and McCormack 2020] or the critical provocations embedded in the *Bot of Conviction* [Roussou et al. 2019]. This observation does not diminish their conceptual contributions, but instead raises the challenge: What kinds of interactional structure might bridge contemplation

and consequence, prompting reflection that is not only felt but also enacted? This question calls for closer examination, which we take up in the next chapter through case studies of specific artworks.

3 INSPIRATION AND INVESTIGATION

3.1 Draw Inspiration from Cases

Our analysis of cultural criminology-based artwork shows that interaction is often used to foster empathy and position the artwork as a reflective warning, encouraging visitors to critically engage with issues of crime and justice (see Figure 2). Michelle Handelman’s *Beware the Lily Law* [Handelman 2023], staged inside a decommissioned prison cell, uses video monologues from formerly incarcerated transgender individuals to recreate the psychological intensity of solitary confinement [Tsai and Huang 2024]. By requiring participants to sit alone and listen in darkness, the work transfers the isolation of imprisonment to the viewer’s body, transforming passive observation into a visceral experience. Similarly, JR’s *Tehachapi Prison* projects monumental portraits of inmates on prison walls [JR 2023], obscuring spatial and symbolic boundaries between incarcerated bodies and public participants. In addition, other works prioritize dialogical structures that invite ethical reflection—Sharon Daniel’s *Public Secrets* and *Inside the Distance* present voice-based archives of incarcerated individuals and mediators within restorative justice systems [Daniel 2007, 2013]. These interactive platforms decentralize the artist’s authority and the listening of testimonials in the background as a political act. However, art has been fully demonstrated through carefully designed interactive elements that require people to take responsibility on both the moral and emotional levels [Jacobsen 2016].

3.2 Conduct Investigation from Professional

Interview with Law Enforcement. We conducted semi-structured interviews with ten professionals (N=10; 7 males, 3 females; M = 34.6, SD = 11.3) to gain insight into the intersections of crime and

artistic creation. The conversations focused on three themes: (1) participants' conceptualizations of police interrogation; (2) reflections on how crime-related practices can be represented or reinterpreted through art; and (3) ethical considerations, particularly with respect to responsibility and boundaries of artistic participation. The respondents also suggested potential contexts for applying these ideas, offering grounded perspectives that informed our subsequent case analysis (see Figure 3).

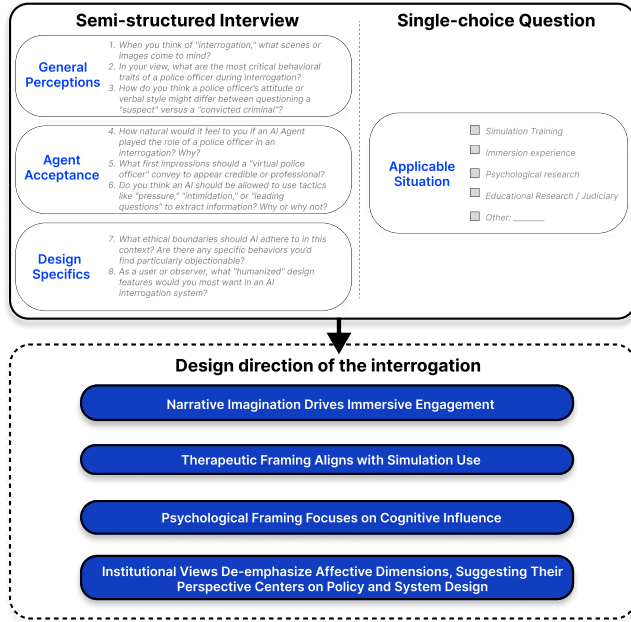


Figure 3: Semi-structured interview framework and derived design directions for Interrogator. Prompts and a scenario item were administered to ten professionals; synthesis produced four directions.

Key Insights from the Investigation. To examine how the preferences of the scenarios of the participants relate to their views on AI interrogators, we performed a mixed methods analysis. Eight open responses were coded using a rule-based keyword scheme across five themes: *AI identity*, *artistic expression*, *coercion*, *ethics*, and *empathy*. These responses are categorized according to the selected application scenarios (Q9): (1) simulation training, (2) immersion experience, (3) psychological research, (4) educational research / judiciary and (5) others.

The scenario preferences of the interviewees revealed divergent visions of how such systems might be applied. Some imagined immersive or game-like settings, where the agent functioned as a transparent, story-driven identity construct suited for speculative or experiential engagement. Others highlighted psychological or research-related uses, highlighting the agent's ability to influence subtly, logical reasoning, and mental pressure, particularly its ability to shape user thoughts and emotional states. Others suggested applications in legal or educational domains, framing the agent as a tool for instruction, discipline, or even propagandistic training. However, these scenarios, especially those that involve didactic or

coercive functions, underscore the need for more rigorous design considerations to prevent misuse and to safeguard ethical boundaries (see Figure 3).

4 DESIGN METHODS

4.1 Interrogator Agent

Emotional Interaction. The installation constructs a real-time perceptual profile of participants by combining computer vision, audio analysis, and gestural recognition, processed through a Python module connected with Unity. Facial emotion recognition classifies expressions into seven categories (e.g., fear, anger, neutrality) with intensity scores to indicate vulnerability or resistance, while real-time speech recognition enables conversational exchanges with the agent (see Figure 4). In addition, a symbolic gesture—placing hands within a predefined spatial zone—is interpreted as an act of submission, activating the interrogation loop. By synthesizing these multimodal inputs, the system generates an affective profile that dynamically shapes the agent's dialogue and embodied feedback, positioning the participant's psychological state as the central driver of the unfolding interaction. Building on this perceptual layer, the system implements a valence-weighted multi-emotion scoring model to drive agent behavior. For each utterance, emotion probabilities are aggregated into a polarity-weighted score:

$$E = \sum_i (\text{score}_i \times \text{valence}_i), \quad E \in [-3, +3]$$

This score is mapped to four behavioral zones:

- **Negative** ($E \in [-3, -1]$): confrontational mode with high-intensity animations (e.g., accusatory gestures).
- **Neutral** ($E \in (-1, +1)$): steady and observational with minimal expression.
- **Positive** ($E \in [+1, +2.5]$): affiliative behaviors such as nodding or encouragement.
- **Suspiciously Positive** ($E > +2.5$): guarded acknowledgment to suggest possible insincerity.

By embedding suspicion of exaggerated affect into its behavioral model, the agent achieves psychological realism, reinforcing the tension and uncertainty central to interrogation dynamics.

Agent Strategy Generation and Behavioral Modulation. The interrogating agent within the installation acts as both a rhetorical and a performative entity as the hidden "inquisitionist". Its verbal behavior is generated via the Qianfan LLM and Baidu Cloud Server¹. The agent is not simply reactive, but strategically adaptive: it modifies its tone, posture, and linguistic content in response to the participant's real-time affective state and score. Moreover, the agent is not a passive mirror, but an active interpreter and amplifier of participant behavior. Fear or defiance of the participant does not just reflect in the system – the result is an affective feedback loop in which machine perception and human response escalate one another iteratively.

4.2 Spatial Orchestration

The installation is conceived as a dialogue between virtual projection and the embodied environment, each reinforcing the authority

¹<https://cloud.baidu.com/>

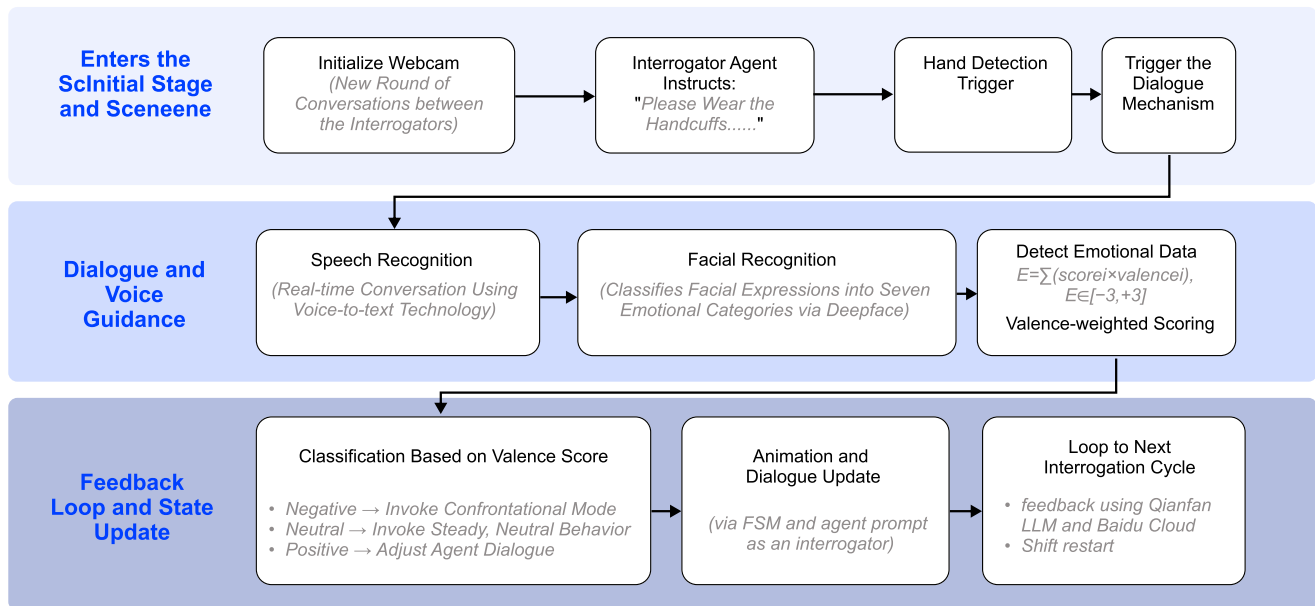


Figure 4: Workflow of the Interrogator system: multimodal inputs (gesture, speech, facial emotion) are scored and mapped to behavioral states, driving adaptive dialogue and feedback cycles for a realistic interrogation interaction.

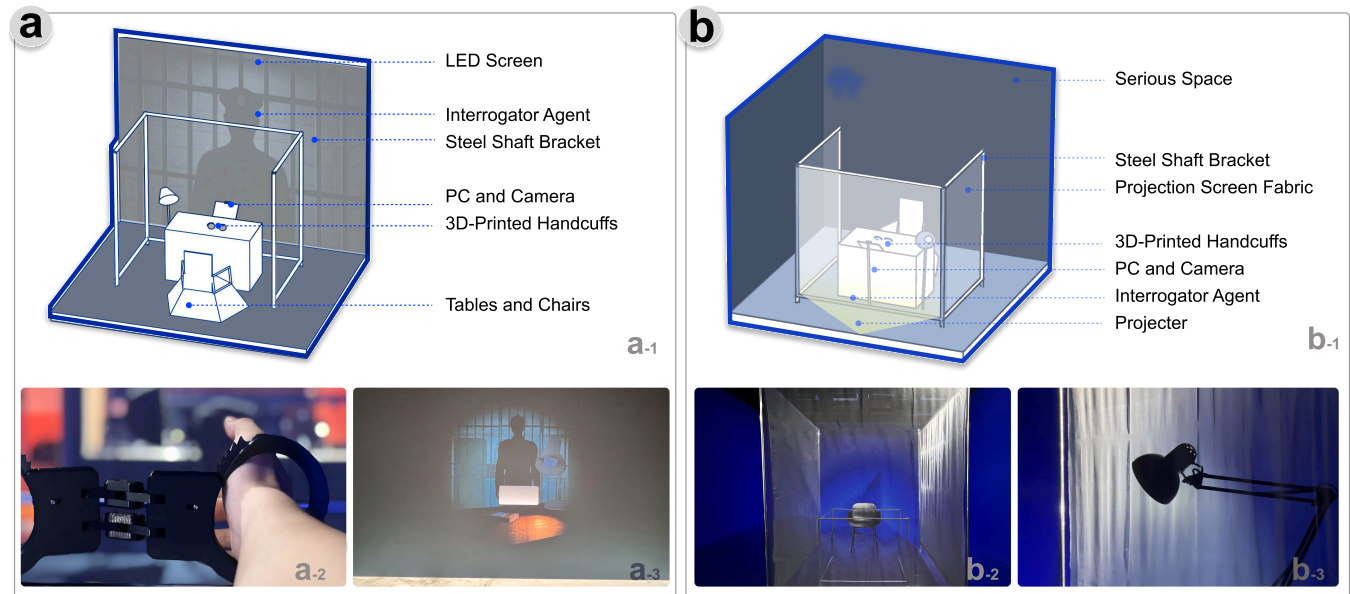


Figure 5: Two iterative phases of the Interrogator installation. Phase 1 (a) staged authority through LED screens and shadow projection as a symbolic prototype, integrating insights from the formative study on institutional atmosphere and scripted questioning. Phase 2 (b) expanded into an immersive projection environment emphasizing affective control, incorporating additional formative insights on spatial confinement and adaptive dialogue. The second phase was publicly exhibited, with visitor feedback further refining the project's critical exploration of authority, agency, and reflection.

and intensity of interrogation. The virtual setting, built in Unity as a single-point perspective room, presents participants with an AI interrogator through a projected screen. Its visual austerity—bare

surfaces, compressed perspective, and minimal furnishings—evokes the psychological weight of institutional confinement. This is not

simply a representational stage: socket-based protocols stream affective data from a perception module, while HTTP connections link to remote LLMs, enabling dialogue that adapts dynamically to the visitor's emotional state.

The physical staging extends this logic to a sensorial register. Installed in a darkened and acoustically sealed room, with directional lighting and constrained entryways, the atmosphere mirrors the spatial grammar of the interrogation chambers, increasing isolation and anticipatory tension [Cao et al. 2021]. Crucially, the environment acts not as a neutral background, but as an active agent priming the emotional response. Once visitors place their hands in the trigger zone, a structured loop begins – question, response, emotion parsing, agent reaction, and follow-up – coordinated by a central flow manager (GameFlowManager), a Unity script responsible for sequencing the interrogation loop. This embodied circuit continues until the hands are withdrawn, at which point the system resets. Each encounter is thus discrete yet ritually repeatable, echoing the cyclical logic of institutional interrogation while foregrounding the affective interplay between visitor and machine.

5 DISPLAY, VISITOR ENGAGEMENT AND OBSERVATION

The **Interrogator** installation was publicly exhibited in two venues, with adjustments tailored to the characteristics of each hall. Visitors (N = 29) were invited to experience the work, after which semi-structured interviews were conducted to gather reflections on their engagement.

5.1 Phase 1: Art Installation – the First Trial

The first phase of the installation was presented in a studio as the symbolic prototype. A simple Unity-based system was combined with LED lighting and a webcam to simulate a basic interrogation scenario. The invited visitors sat in front of a virtual agent, responding to prescribed instructions while being visually monitored. Located within an educational space, it invited critical reflection on authority, control, and the emotional atmosphere of institutional scrutiny – the interrogator focused on questioning "AI and academic misconduct". During this interactive process, we invited the students (n = 14) to have a deep experience.

5.2 Phase 2: Interrogation with Agent

The second phase, shown in a public awareness venue, expanded the installation into a more immersive and emotionally charged experience. The projection replaced the LED screens, transforming the space into a visually dominant interrogation zone. The AI agent was upgraded with real-time emotional analysis and adaptive dialogue, allowing it to change tones based on the affect of the user. The visitors faced the agent under stark lighting while physically restrained, enhancing the psychological realism. This iteration went beyond symbolic signals, directly engaging visitors (n = 15) in an emotionally responsive system that blurred the lines between control, empathy, and mechanistic judgment.

5.3 Perspectives and Changes

To investigate how individuals adapt to and reflect on interactions with AI-driven authority, we conducted a semistructured interview

study involving interaction with the interrogator agent, using thematic analysis and comparison methods to summarize its main theme. Five open questions guided the interviews, investigating strategic response patterns, awareness of guidance, sensitivity to linguistic pressure, and lasting reflections.

Dominant Theme: AI-specific interaction strategies. Throughout both interview phases, visitors consistently demonstrated a high degree of strategic engagement with the AI agent, with *AI Interaction Strategy* emerging as the dominant and stable theme. The mention of this theme increased substantially in Phase 2, particularly in response to direct questioning and perceived control mechanisms (see Table 1), suggesting a growing familiarity with the inference logic of the system. As one participant from Phase 2 reflected, "*I wasn't just answering; I was thinking two steps ahead: What will AI conclude from this?*" (P31-II). This forward-modeling mindset framed the interaction less as compliance and more as a tactical dialog.

Other Themes. In contrast, themes such as *Strategic Silence* and *Judgment Timing* evolved more subtly. Although silence decreased during active interaction, it reappeared in reflective questions, indicating retrospective awareness of withholding as a form of resistance. One participant noted, "*When it kept circling back to the same question, he realized that staying silent was my safest option.*" (P31-II). Similarly, as one participant put it, "*If a question sounded loaded, I paused to test if it was probing for a slip*" (P13-I). This also emphasizes that more immersive interaction methods – such as simulating darker scenes and contrasting with strong lighting – may offer a more immersive experience in art exhibitions. In general, these trends illustrate a movement from reactive caution to reflective agency. As visitors progressed through the system—and through phases, they began to treat AI not as merely a threat or authority, but as a *discipline structure to be managed*. In some cases, transformed into calibrated self-presentation.

6 DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

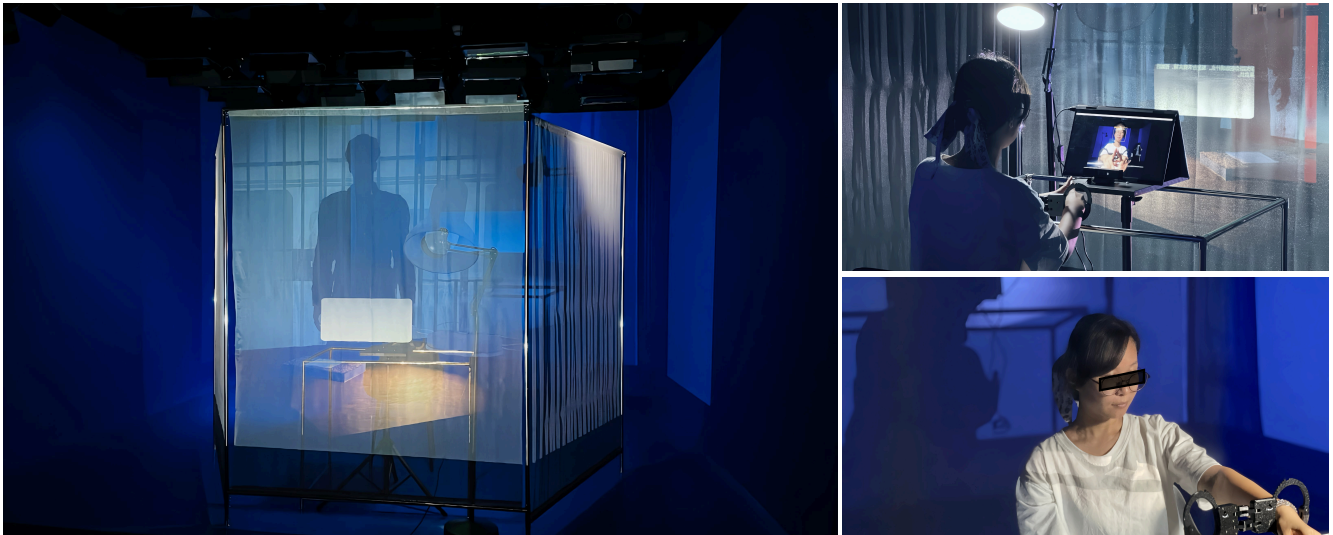
6.1 From Reactive to Reflective Practices

This artistic study shows how AI-mediated interrogation not only triggers reactive strategies in the moment, but also reshapes the scaffolding of self-reflection. Invited visitors who engaged with the virtual police agent did not simply report surface impressions or emotional reactions—they began to describe their behaviors in terms of tactical decisions, ethical positioning, and linguistic performance. As revealed in our thematic analysis, practices such as timing, silence, and truth-telling were no longer framed as passive states but as reflective strategies: deciding when to speak, how to speak, and what it means to withhold. In this sense, the AI agent functioned not only as an interrogator but as a mirror, provoking forms of self-monitoring that extended beyond the interaction itself.

What emerges here is a shift from reflection-as-evaluation ("*Did I answer well?*") to reflection-as-structure ("*What kind of discourse was I part of?*"). This transformation suggests that AI agents, especially when embedded in institutional or authoritative frameworks, have the capacity to restructure how individuals narrate responsibility, manage ambiguity, and anticipate misrecognition. These are not merely psychological adjustments—they are linguistic and

Table 1: Thematic Frequency Matrix Across Questions

The Identified Theme	Q1: Strategy		Q2: Awareness		Q3: Power		Q4: Change		Q5: Feedback		Total
	Phase 1	Phase 2	Phase 1	Phase 2	Phase 1	Phase 2	Phase 1	Phase 2	Phase 1	Phase 2	
AI Interaction Strategy	9	18	7	12	3	11	14	10	3	9	96
Judgment Timing	2	10	3	1	6	4	1	0	2	0	29
Strategic Silence	8	4	0	2	0	1	0	3	0	2	20
Truth-telling / Admission	1	2	0	2	0	0	0	2	0	1	8
Information Evasion	5	4	0	0	1	0	0	1	0	1	12
Behavioral Adjustment	1	1	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	3

**Figure 6: A visitor engages with the interrogator agent in an immersive projection space, from entering the setting to initiating dialogue and performing with handcuffs. Images reproduced with participant authorization.**

moral recalibrations that reflect the growing entanglement between human agency and algorithmic governance [Li et al. 2024].

6.2 Agent-Driven Participatory Art

Unlike conventional installations, where visitors mainly observe and interpret, this work required them to actively negotiate meaning through exchanges with an adaptive system. This type of interaction resonates with criminological insights into how authority is staged and tested, but extends them to the domain of participatory art; From a user experience perspective, the installation can be read as a prototype for critical encounters [Guo 2025; Mayer 2014]. Design choices, such as affective sensing, dialog modulation, and spatial choreography, created new ways for visitors to engage.

Equally significant is how visitor strategies connected with, and sometimes challenged, criminology and AI ethics. Practices such as strategic silence, calibrated timing, and selective disclosure echoed debates about power negotiation, consent, and coercion in institutional contexts. The embodied experience of being interrogated by a machine made these abstract theories tangible, showing how participatory art can render theoretical concerns experientially

accessible. Although this study does not seek to redefine criminological frameworks, it demonstrates how artistic practice can extend and illustrate key ideas by embedding them in lived experience.

6.3 Reflexivity

From the perspective of professionals engaged in interrogation practices (e.g., law enforcement officers, public officials), the interest is not in replacing human work with AI, but in how such systems might complement institutional practices of prevention, reflection, and regulation. From a cultural criminology perspective, artists similarly ask how to provoke thought and self-examination through their own means. The question of agency thus engages not only criminologists and artists, but also technical designers and policymakers.

The exhibition of the installation in multiple venues reinforced this point. Visitors were not merely shaped by the system. They adapted to it, subverted it, and at times resisted it. Rather than perceiving the AI agent as a fixed interrogator, they increasingly treated it as an *interactive environment* in which the agency could be negotiated. In this sense, visitors learned not only to endure but also to strategically manage computational structures of power.

This emphasizes that the contribution of the work is not to redefine criminology as a discipline, but to extend its concerns into a new experiential domain — foregrounding how audiences can reflect upon authority, consent, and coercion through embodied artistic encounters.

Acknowledgments

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